BJP). The job of the panna pramukhs was to convert C category voters to B and B category voters to A.

In tandem with the panna pramukhs, in 2017 in UP, the BJP instituted a parallel system of constituency oversight through the deployment of what the party called ‘vistaraks’ (expanders). In each of the 403 UP Vidhan Sabha constituencies and eighty Lok Sabha seats in 2019, it posted a vistarak. These were deeply ideological party workers who volunteered to spend between six to twelve months working in constituencies away from their homes. They were deployed in constituencies ‘100/150/200 km away’ from their own seats for long periods. Their job was to function as external listening posts for the central leadership in these areas. The vistaraks could not interfere with the local leadership but were tasked with providing daily parallel feedback and ‘whole detailed ground reports’ to the party on what was really happening, over and above what the local units were telling their superiors. As one local leader told me, they would provide inputs like ‘the president is not working, or is not intervening or this community [biradari] is not voting for us or voting for us. This issue is there or not there.’

Vistaraks were volunteers who undertook this intelligence-gathering work free of cost. The party provided them with boarding and lodging. As the leader explained, ‘If, for example, I give the party one year or so, they would send me 100/150/km way to Faizabad or Azamgarh. I will be given one vidhan sabha there. The sangathan there would keep doing its own work separately. From that sangathan I only get my stay, food and stay in touch … Apart from that, I cannot interfere in the sangathan there, but the whole day I will move around for the party’s work: in different communities [samaaj], in meetings, in party meetings, in offices.’

These workers provided a parallel channel of ground information to the party’s planners. The role of ideology was paramount here. ‘Our biggest success was that we could take out such workers,’ said the local leader. ‘The party thought of this, yes, but that many people were ready to do this and came out, this was a big thing for a year.’ The importance of the vistaraks was that, when a ‘neta goes, people speak to him because everyone want to engage